

THE GETTYSBURG ADDRESS

THE GETTYSBURG FILES - ARCHIVE CASE #272

ANALYST BRIEFING

FROM EFFECT TO INTERPRETATION

When a task asks you to analyse or examine a text and consider both the line of argument and the use of stylistic devices, your analysis should move from the general effect of a device to its specific function within the argument.

Stage	Focus	What does this mean?	Example: Lincoln's repetition of 'we cannot'
Stage 1 · Basic Analysis	GENERAL EFFECT	What does the device generally do? This effect could apply to many different texts.	The repetition draws the audience's attention to the phrase and makes it more memorable.
Stage 2 · Developed Analysis	MEANING IN CONTEXT	What does the device emphasize or express in this specific passage?	By repeating 'we cannot', Lincoln emphasizes that words and ceremonial acts cannot equal the soldiers' sacrifice.
Stage 3 · Advanced Interpretation	FUNCTION IN THE LINE OF ARGUMENT	Why does the speaker or author use the device at this particular point, and how does it develop the argument?	Lincoln shifts the focus from what the audience has come to do at Gettysburg to what the soldiers have already done. This prepares his later appeal to the living to continue their unfinished work.



A strong analysis does not stop at the general effect of a stylistic device. It explains what the device means in context and how it contributes to the line of argument.

ADDITIONAL METHOD SHEET

WORKING WITH THE METHOD SHEET

Familiarise yourself with the following method sheet. It provides a comprehensive overview of possible aspects to consider when analysing political speeches. In most tasks, you will neither need nor be expected to analyse all of them. Always select the aspects that help you answer the specific task: **Focus only on the aspects relevant to the task.**

Optional practice

Work through the method sheet once with the *Gettysburg Address* in mind. Compare its categories and explanations with the analysis you have already completed. Mark or label the stages of the speech's line of argument and the stylistic devices that correspond to aspects described in the method sheet.

